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**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)

**Region:** Africa

**Sub Region:** Southern Africa

**Field Date:** Late 1960s

**Coverage Date:** Not Specified

**Place Coverage:** !Kung San, Botswana And Namibia

**Section Title(S):** Diversity Of Bushman Society

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Social organization also varies from group to group in both specific social institutions and the basic social structure. Regarding the former, one can point to marriage, postmarital residence patterns, and kinship terminology, all of them varying widely, as so cogently demonstrated by Alan Barnard (1992a, especially chapter 15; also see chapter 2 this volume). Joking and avoidance relationships are typical but not universal kin categories and the well-known namesake relationship is a very rare pattern found primarily amongst the well-known !Kung. Political and religious status differentiation is another variable aspect of Bushman social organization (Barnard 1992a, especially chapter 13). The shaman-like medicine men were professionalized and organized amongst some groups (such as the nineteenth-century Cape /Xam [Hewitt 1986:287–99] or the Ghanzi Nharo [Passarge 1907:108–9; Guenther 1975, 1986a:262–9, 288–9]), whilst amongst other groups, such as the Nyae Nyae !Kung, “it is rare to find a man ... who is not a medicine man” (Marshall 1965:271).

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The political role of headman may vary with respect to the degree of power it entails, from virtually none — the “Common Bushman” (i.e. !Kung or G/wi pattern) — to formidable. Power also varies according to whether it is achieved, through personal success and charisma, or ascribed. In the latter

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instance headmanship would usually be patrilineally bequeathed, as is or was the case, for instance, among the !Kung-speaking Aakwankala (or !Xū) of Ovamboland (Williams 1991:86), the !Kxo (Heinz 1994:76–101), or the early Nharo of Sandfontein at the Botswana-Namibia border (Bleek 1928:36). The status of headman is usually held by a man; as discussed elsewhere (Guenther 1983), the reasons have to do with the hunt, a subsistence activity with political potential. However, on this score, too, there appear to be exceptions. For instance, amongst the !Kung, whose “*k’xau n!asi* [headman] are as thin as the rest” (Marshall 1976:194) and who are devoid of regalia or special honors or tribute (see also Lee 1984:89), women, too, can be headmen, according to one ethnographer (Lee 1979:344–9). It should be noted, however, that another !Kung researcher (Marshall 1976:194) states categorically that such could never be the case amongst the Nyae Nyae people. She draws a distinction 71 between “owners” of *n!ores* and headmen of bands; the former can, and the latter cannot, be women.

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